

Philosophy of Teaching

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Rather than asking ourselves who is responsible for learning as if it were another discussion about a chicken and an egg, we should ask how we learn from each other as students and/or teachers as if it were two sides to the same coin. It is not possible, I believe, to impact a human being without being reciprocally impacted by that human being. Students and teachers all have a responsibility for learning. Teachers are responsible to students for preparation, consideration of individuals, and effective pedagogy. Students have a responsibility to teachers for motivation to learn. How the two interact and impact each other can and should be different for different people at different times. I bring to counselor education the willingness to allow students to teach me. I bring the ability to change pedagogy for unique situations and unique people. I bring the attitude that ambivalence is fertile soil for growth and development, but structure is the plow that prepares the soil for seed.

Theory

Kolb's theory highlights the need to utilize different teaching styles (from observation and articulation of ideas to activities that allow students to engage with hands-on concepts to encouraging discussion on theory and philosophy) to engage different learning styles (Svinicki & McKeachie, 2014). Kolb's theory paints a picture of individuality for me. It paints a picture of the arrogance of believing that one model fits all students. This arrogance is what I hope to eliminate from myself and my teaching as I see students' individual needs and address them creatively and mindfully. The idea of creativity brings to mind Piaget's constructivism. His theory that activity on the part of the learner is the key to the growth of knowledge (Hyde, 2020) reminds me that boring teachers are ineffective teachers. Creativity can be found in all sorts of places if one keeps an open mind.

Nevertheless, the most helpful idea related to creativity reflects on my first thought that teachers can continuously learn from students. Students have great ideas about how they learn. A teacher can stay creative in the moment through discussions, groups, and open dialogue.

Competency and Assessment

Creativity, individuality, and continuous learning also play a part in the assessment of learning. When one keeps student growth at the forefront of assessment practices, it is possible to utilize specific, measurable outcomes to determine the effectiveness of one's teaching. Structure, as mentioned before, plays a critical role in assessment as well as instruction. To expect students to excel without proper instruction is unrealistic. Therefore, helping students understand that assessment is not just for grading purposes and may only sometimes be what they expect is part of effective education. When structuring the assessment of learning, the Council for Accreditation of Counseling and Related Educational Programs offers eight areas of curricular experience required to prepare all counselors: (1) professional counseling orientation and ethical practice, (2) social and cultural diversity, (3) human growth and development, (4) career development, (5) counseling and helping relationships, (6) group counseling and group work, (7) assessment and testing, and (8) research and program evaluation (CACREP, 2023). Highlighting and structuring around these eight areas helps the teacher plow the field and helps the student assimilate the information for growth and not simply a grade.

Conclusion

To see counselor education as two sides of the same coin where student and teacher have responsibilities to each other for development and growth centers my instruction on the learner rather than on the content. Anyone can present material, assign a book, show a video, or ask students to discuss amongst themselves. However, an educator will meet the student where she is

and develop and strategy for teaching her that engages the whole person. Counselor educators are responsible for developing students' intra and interpersonal skills in the hope that they will become healers through relationships and not information alone.

This is really well written, Ray. I think you highly important areas in which counselors in training will develop specific skills to become competent and effective in the field. A couple things to strengthen its overall grounding:

1. Ask yourself, what do I bring to the counselor education field that might be different than let's say, Krista Kirk? In other words, what specific characteristics do you see in yourself that you bring to the classroom that will help enhance what you mention above? For example, you're discussing a constructivism lens- how will you interweave that into your curriculum development and learner-center strategies?
2. Think through a lens in which you see teaching and learning. For example, my lens is distinctly aligned with the theoretical model that psychological safety and gatekeeping are one-in-the-same. Students need to feel safe to take risks and grow. So for you, when you're discussing your "mission statement" of reciprocal learning, how does that influence your curriculum and lesson plans? How might it even influence assessment? Sounds to me like there is quite a lot of dispositional assessment too (in that). Ask yourself, if someone was to ask you, "what's your philosophy on how counselors-in-training become good counselors?" What immediately comes to mind for you? You can interweave that all throughout the document.
3. I mentioned above the core components of counseling programs and how they serve as a foundation for CE programs (esp CACREP ones). So what does Ray bring that is in addition to that foundation? Who are YOU in the classroom and how does that influence the way you teach/assess/engage?

You have a great start here. Feel free to keep working on it and send it to me (or your advisors) for continued feedback.

References

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